The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: Getty Images

Iran appeared to pour scorn on America's reported 15-point ceasefire proposal. A senior official called the plan "excessive" and said Iran would only stop fighting on its own terms, state media reported. The official also set out Iran's own conditions for ending the war, which include sovereignty over the Strait of Hormuz. President Donald Trump has insisted America is in contact with the "right people" in Iran.

Meanwhile, **Iran** warned America not to "test our resolve to defend our land" after reports that the Trump administration is preparing to send around 2,000 **troops** to the **Middle East**. According to the *New York Times*, the paratroopers might be used to seize Kharg Island, an Iranian energy hub. The deployment will add to the 50,000 troops already assigned to Operation Epic Fury.

A jury in Los Angeles found **Meta** and **YouTube** liable in a landmark **social-media addiction trial**. A 20-year-old woman alleged their platforms are designed to be addictive, which harmed her mental health; they were ordered to pay $3m in total damages. (TikTok and Snap, also named in the original complaint, settled before the trial). The verdict could influence similar cases in America. Both companies will appeal against the ruling.

Merck & Co agreed to buy Terns Pharmaceuticals in a deal worth $6.7bn. The American pharma giant (not to be confused with a similarly named German firm) has made several big acquisitions recently as it prepares for patents of its best-selling cancer drug, Keytrude, to begin expiring from 2028. Terns has revealed promising early-stage trial results for its experimental treatment for chronic myeloid leukemia.

Oil prices continued their rollercoaster ride. Traders, believing Mr Trump's talk of possible peace, briefly sent the price of Brent crude, the global benchmark, below $100 a barrel. In what could be taken as a sign of alarming cognitive dissonance, stockmarkets are optimistic. America's S&P 500 rose by more than 0.6%, while Europe's Stoxx 600 climbed by 1.4%.

Matt Brittin, a former Google executive, will be the **BBC's** next boss. The previous director-general resigned over a broadcast which falsely made it appear as though Mr Trump had called for rioters to attack the Capitol in Washington, DC on January 6th 2021. The president is suing the BBC. Mr Brittin must also deal with tough competition from streaming services and declining trust in traditional news sources.

Workers found a skeleton that may be that of **D'Artagnan**, a French soldier who inspired the hero in Alexandre Dumas's novel, "The Three Musketeers", beneath a church in Maastricht. The swashbuckler was killed during a siege of the Dutch city in 1673. A French coin from 1660 and a musket ball buried nearby point to a possible match. Archaeologists will compare DNA from the remains with D'Artagnan's descendants.

Figure of the day: $550bn. The valuation of ByteDance as of February. Read about how the Chinese tech giant is swallowing the internet.

Photograph: Reuters

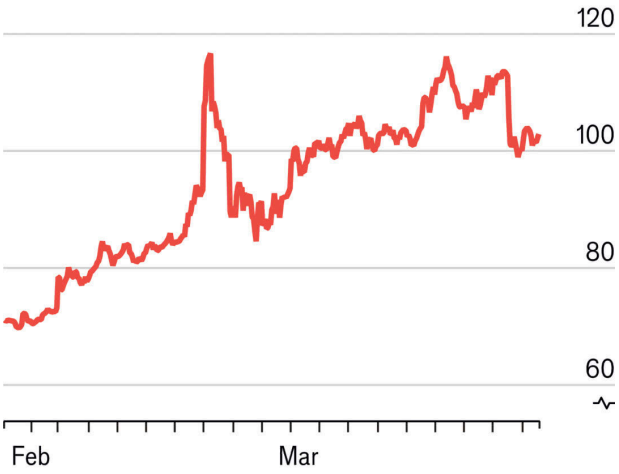
Big Oil’s bittersweet bonanza

CERAWeek, the energy industry’s Davos (just with less snow, being in Texas), has never drawn bigger crowds—nor more anxious ones. The oil price see-saws with each new development in the Iran war. Goldman Sachs, a bank, has just revised its forecast for the average price this year upward by $8 a barrel. Foreign customers are begging American exporters of liquefied natural gas to help replace supplies stuck on the wrong side of the Strait of Hormuz.

So why are energy bosses, who would normally toast $100 oil, nervously swallowing their whisky in Houston this week? The biggest Western oil firms have a chunk of assets frozen in the Middle East; over a fifth of the expected cash flows of BP and ExxonMobil this year are at risk. Meanwhile, America’s shale producers, sitting on windfall profits, are hedging rather than drilling. Rystad Energy, a consultancy, warns that unless high prices last for months, shale exploration and production companies are unlikely to revise their plans.

Gulps and gushes

Brent crude oil price*, 2026, $ per barrel



Source: LSEG Workspace

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Photograph: Getty Images

CPAC stands by its man

A few hours north of the oilmen in Houston, Republicans will gather near Dallas on Wednesday for CPAC, an annual conservative conference. Iran will loom large there too. President Donald Trump says America and Iran are having “very good and productive conversations”. (Iranian officials deny this.) How will conservatives at home view his new tone?

Some influential conservatives dislike the war. Tucker Carlson, for example, told *The Economist* that bombing Iran was the “inverse” of America First principles. But the president’s base backs him. Polling from YouGov suggests that 77% of MAGA Republicans think the war is justified, compared with 68% of Republicans more broadly. That support should be on display at CPAC. Matt Schlapp, the organisation’s chairman, recently argued that Mr Trump must know something most Americans don’t about Iran’s nuclear capabilities. The war is a risk in an election year, he admitted, but “I trust him”.

Photograph: EPA

Just as things were looking up for Germany

Last month the mood of Germany's business leaders had improved. They were cheered by signs of recovery in Germany's manufacturing, services and construction sectors, according to data compiled by the Munich-based Ifo Institute. But new figures for March released on Wednesday revealed that their sentiment has soured again amid the war in Iran. Europe's largest economy is especially vulnerable to oil-price shocks: its industrial sector uses nearly twice as much energy as the next-biggest in Europe.

According to the German Economic Institute in Cologne, a rise in the price of oil to $100 per barrel could make German GDP 0.3% smaller than it would have been this year and 0.6% smaller in 2027. That would be a loss of economic output of €40bn ($46bn) over two years. Inflation will also rise again. If Donald Trump ends the war soon, as he sounded eager to do on Monday, the business outlook could improve. But his words came too late to cheer up German bosses in time for the Ifo poll.

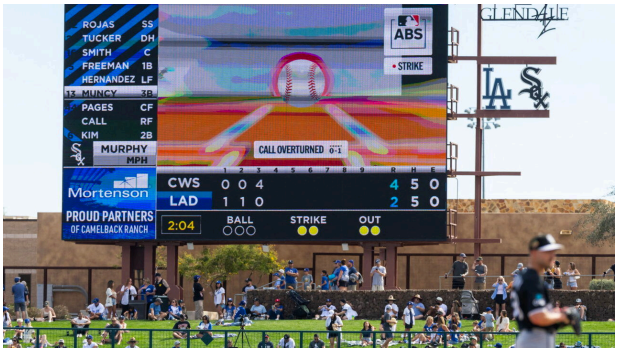
Photograph: News Licensing

The first female Archbishop of Canterbury

On Wednesday Dame Sarah Mullally has been enthroned at Canterbury Cathedral. She is the first woman to lead the Church of England. The country's established church crowns monarchs and educates a quarter of English schoolchildren. Its 26 bishops have permanent seats in Parliament. (The only other country that automatically gives clerics seats in its legislature is Iran.)

Archbishop Mulally's job will not be easy. Many of the world's 100m Anglicans, who view the Church of England as their "mother church", nonetheless do not think a woman should lead it. The institution is still dealing with scandals caused by past abuse of children. An experiment to introduce blessings for gay couples has fractured the church along ideological lines.

The church is doing zany things to grow its dwindling flock. Last year a graffiti installation on Canterbury Cathedral's walls posed questions like "Why did you create hate when love is by far more powerful?" America's vice-president, J.D. Vance, a Roman Catholic, took notice: he called the installation "ugly".



Photograph: Reuters

A new dimension of baseball

For years, tennis and cricket players have been able to dispute umpires' calls. In those sports, each side can challenge a limited number of decisions per set or innings. The 2026 Major League Baseball season, which begins on Wednesday in San Francisco, will field its own version of this for the first time.

As before, umpires will decide whether a pitched ball has entered a batter's strike zone (miss three balls in the strike zone and you are out). But now the pitcher, catcher or batter can challenge the call by tapping his helmet. When that happens the new Automated Ball-Strike system, relying on cameras, will judge whether the ball is a strike. It will also show the ball and the strike zone (which changes with the size of the batter) to fans inside and outside the stadium. The new system will have an effect on tactics: teams will have to use their two challenges judiciously.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Wednesday: What is the term for the annual celebration that occurs in many countries when the crops have been gathered?

Tuesday: Clover, buckwheat and manuka are types of what food product?

I write because I don’t know what I think until I read what I say.

Flannery O’Connor